

From Crackers to Series

Pirates' Tanner Gets Most From Players the Easy Way

By TIM TUCKER
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PITTSBURGH—All week, Chuck Tanner has been in demand.

If he's not talking to a newspaper reporter, he's standing in front of a television camera. If someone isn't shaking his hand, someone else is patting him on the back. If there isn't a crowd around him, then you can be certain one's on their way.

It's a long way from the early 1950s when he was an outfielder for the Atlanta Crackers, playing at Ponce de Leon Park with little hope of ever seeing the major leagues.

Those days are long gone, but hardly forgotten.

"Those were the days,"

says Tanner, now the manager of the National League champion Pittsburgh Pirates. "That was a great life."

Those were the days of dollar-a-day meal money and four players to a room on the road, so distantly removed from today's standard of living in baseball. Tanner played for the Crackers from 1951 through 1954 before making the Milwaukee Braves' team in 1955 at the age of 26.

He remembers much about Atlanta, but particularly the park ("such atmosphere"), the fans ("some of the best") and the writers ("some of my best friends.")

"It's still one of my favorite places to go back to," he says. "It'd be nice if we were playing the Braves in the

playoffs."

Now, as one of the most successful and respected managers in baseball, the 50-year-old Tanner points to the manager of the 1954 Crackers, Whitlow Wyatt, as perhaps the man who most shaped his style. Today, Wyatt lives on a farm in Buchanan, Ga.

"I like to tell myself I learned a lot from Charlie Grimm, Gene Mauch, Dixie Walker, Fred Haney and Andy Cohen," said Tanner, who played for 15 managers during his 17 years in the majors and minors. "But I'd have to say that Whitlow Wyatt influenced me more than anyone."

"I'll tell you why. Nothing a manager does is more



Chuck Tanner

important than instilling the proper attitude in his players. And Wyatt handled the players on our 1954 team better than any manager I've ever known."

Tanner's managerial style is one of co-existence, not domination. His players like him, and he likes them. He is able to be one of the guys without sacrificing discipline.

Strategically, he often goes away from baseball convention. He goes with hunches more than most managers, leaving himself vulnerable to criticism in seasons less successful than this one. But the Tanner method has worked so well he has finished lower than second only four times in 10 seasons of managing in the majors.

"There aren't many managers in baseball like him," says Pittsburgh General Manager Pete Peterson. "He is tough and easy going at the same time. And he's always so optimistic and enthusiastic and positive, it just rubs off on everyone else."

Those qualities are what Cracker followers remember most about Tanner.

"He has just always been such a pleasant person," says retired sportswriter Charlie Roberts, who covered the Crackers in their heyday for The Atlanta Constitution. "I can't imagine him being as stern as he looks on television some time. I think when he goes out to argue with an umpire and sticks his finger in the guy's face, he's just putting on a show."

Tanner is remembered among Cracker fans as an All-American, bright-eyed, fresh-faced kid. He had four outstanding seasons in Atlanta but was regarded as a career AA player until he suddenly stuck with Milwaukee in the spring of '55.

Tanner's four seasons with the Crackers produced batting averages of .318, .345, .318 and .323 in the old Southern Association. He played six major league seasons with Milwaukee, Chicago and Cleveland before returning to the minor leagues for three more seasons in 1960.